

RH01

Pre-historic and Proto-historic Sites of Rajasthan

About 2-3 questions a paper, and they have come from a small pool - Kalibangan, Ahar, Ganeshwar, Balathal, Ojijana, Bairath. Matching and one-liners dominate; ordering questions appear now and then.

This is the archaeology chapter - mounds, excavators, pottery and rivers. RPSC does not ask you to interpret anything here; it asks site-to-district, site-to-river, site-to-excavator and site-to-that-one-famous-find. Clean tables win these marks.

Pre & Proto-historic Rajasthan

Palaeolithic

- Didwana - Singi Talav (Nagaur)
- Budha Pushkar (Ajmer)
- Luni valley
- Berach valley

Mesolithic

- Bagor - Kothari, Bhilwara
- Tilwara - Luni, Barmer
- Microliths
- Animal domestication c. 5000 BCE

Ahar / Banas

Chalcolithic

- Ahar - Tambavati
- Gilund
- Balathal
- Ojijana
- Black-and-Red Ware

Copper belt

- Ganeshwar - Kantli, Sikar
- Jodhpura - Sabi
- Kurada (Nagaur)
- OCP pottery

Harappan / Bronze Age

- Kalibangan - Ghaggar, Hanumangarh
- Baror (Sri Ganganagar)
- Sothi (Bikaner)
- Rang Mahal

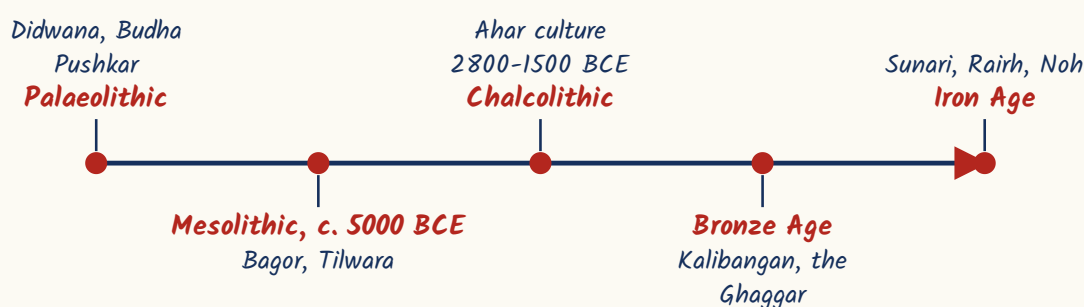
Iron Age & early historic

- Sunari (Jhunjhunu)
- Rairh (Tonk)
- Noh (Bharatpur)
- Nagari (Chittorgarh)
- Bairath (Jaipur)

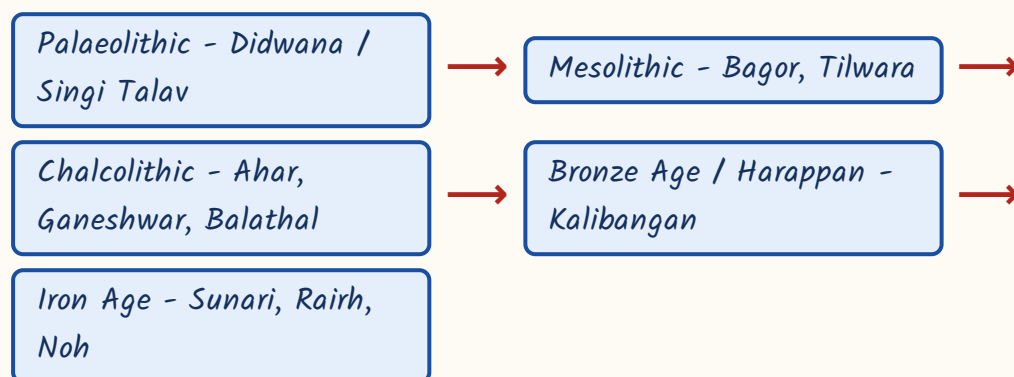
Fix the ladder first - five stages, one anchor site each

Every question in this chapter is really the same question: which stage does this site belong to. So fix the ladder before you learn a single name. Rajasthan's record runs Palaeolithic, then Mesolithic, then Chalcolithic, then Bronze Age (which here means Harappan), then Iron Age. Learn one anchor site per stage and hang everything else on those five pegs. The order itself is asked - Didwana, Bagor, Ahar, Kalibangan, Sunari. D-B-A-K-S.

The cultural ladder - Palaeolithic to Iron Age



The stage ladder - and the exact order RPSC asks



- Palaeolithic - stone hand-axes and flakes, no pottery, no farming; sites sit on old river gravels and lake margins.
- Mesolithic - microliths, that is tiny stone blades; the first animal domestication; Bagor is the type site.
- Chalcolithic - copper and stone used together, settled village farming, Black-and-Red Ware pottery.
- Bronze Age in Rajasthan means the Harappans, and that means Kalibangan and the Ghaggar valley only.
- Iron Age - iron slag, smelting furnaces and punch-marked coins; Sunari, Rairh and Noh.

TRAP

Rajasthan has no separately established Neolithic site of its own. The Mesolithic at Bagor runs straight on into the Chalcolithic. If an option offers you a famous Neolithic site of Rajasthan, treat it with suspicion.

Palaeolithic and Mesolithic - the stone-tool layer

This layer is thin in the exam but it is free marks, because only four or five names exist. All of them are river-valley or lake-margin sites - early humans camped where there was water and where there were pebbles to work.

- Didwana in Nagaur, with its Singi Talav locality, is Rajasthan's best-known Palaeolithic site.
- Budha Pushkar in Ajmer is the other named Palaeolithic site.
- The Luni valley in the west and the Berach valley in Mewar are the two classic Palaeolithic tool-bearing tracts.

Mesolithic - Bagor is basically the whole answer

Bagor in Bhilwara is India's largest and best-documented Mesolithic site. Say that adjective exactly - largest - because that is the wording RPSC uses. It sits on the Kothari river. V.N. Misra dug it between 1967 and 1970.

- Bagor gave some of India's earliest evidence of animal domestication, around 5000 BCE.
- The tool kit is dominated by microliths; five human burials were recovered.
- Tilwara in Barmer is the other Mesolithic site - on the Luni, also excavated by V.N. Misra, 1967-68.

TRAP

Three B-names, three completely different things. Bagor = Mesolithic, Bhilwara, Kothari river. Bairath = Ashokan and Buddhist, Jaipur region. Barli = Rajasthan's oldest inscription, Ajmer. Examiners rotate these three inside one option set.

The Ahar or Banas culture - the heart of the chapter

Ahar culture is the Chalcolithic village culture of southern Rajasthan, roughly 2800 to 1500 BCE. It is also called the Banas culture, after the river system it sits in. Two features define it. One, Black-and-Red Ware pottery carrying white linear designs. Two, heavy use of copper with almost no microliths. That second point is the examiner's favourite - these people had so much copper that they stopped bothering with stone blades.

The four Ahar-culture sites you must be able to place

Site	District	River / setting	The one fact
Ahar (Aghatpur, Aghatdurg)	Udaipur	Ayad-Berach	Called Tambavati - the place of copper

Site	District	River / setting	The one fact
Gilund	Rajsamand	Banas	First dug by B.B. Lal; later Indo-American work
Balathal	Udaipur	Near Udaipur, fortified mound	Oldest skeletal evidence of leprosy in India, c. 2000 BCE
Ojiyana	Bhilwara	Hill slope	Painted bull and cow figurines

- Ahar was first dug by Akshay Kirti Vyas in 1953, then by R.C. Agrawal and H.D. Sankalia in 1961-62.
- Gilund's later excavation was by V.S. Shinde and G.L. Possehl.
- Balathal was excavated by V.N. Misra from 1993; it has a massive fortified enclosure wall.
- Ojiyana was excavated by B.R. Meena of the ASI Jaipur Circle in 1999-2000.
- Tag line for revision - Ahar = copper, Gilund = B.B. Lal, Balathal = leprosy plus fort wall, Ojiyana = figurines.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - the ancient name Tambavati, meaning the place of copper, refers to which site? Answer: Ahar, Udaipur.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - the oldest skeletal evidence of leprosy in India was reported from which Rajasthan site? Answer: Balathal, from a skeleton of about 2000 BCE.

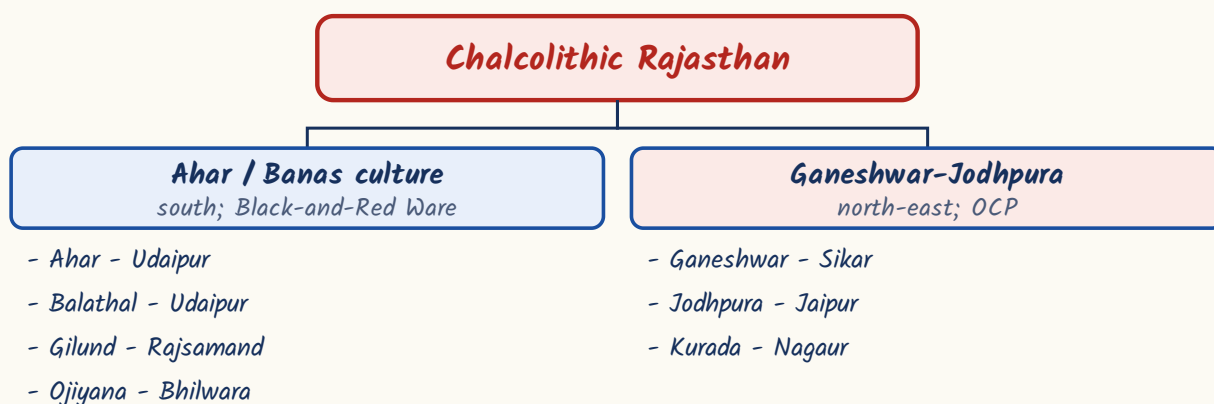
ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - the excavation of Ojiyana was conducted under whose direction? Answer: B.R. Meena, ASI Jaipur Circle, 1999-2000.

Ganeshwar-Jodhpura - the copper belt of the north-east

Different corner of the state, different culture. While Ahar was working copper in the south, a separate copper culture grew up in the north-east, next to the Khetri copper belt. This is the Ganeshwar-Jodhpura culture. Its pottery is Ochre Coloured Pottery, OCP - not Black-and-Red Ware. That single contrast has carried more than one question.

Two Chalcolithic cultures, two corners of the state



- Ganeshwar lies in the Neem ka Thana area of Sikar district, on the Kantli river.
- It was excavated by R.C. Agrawal and Vijay Kumar.
- Over 2,000 copper objects were recovered - arrowheads, fish-hooks, bangles, chisels.
- The culture is believed to have supplied copper to the Harappans.
- Jodhpura, the second name site, lies on the Sabi river in the Jaipur region.
- Kurada in Nagaur is a separate copper-hoard site.

Ahar vs Ganeshwar - the contrast RPSC builds questions on

Ahar / Banas culture	Ganeshwar-Jodhpura culture
Southern Rajasthan - Ayad, Berach, Banas	North-eastern Rajasthan - Kantli, Sabi
Black-and-Red Ware with white linear designs	Ochre Coloured Pottery (OCP)
Copper consumed at the settlement	Copper produced, and probably exported
Udaipur, Rajsamand, Bhilwara	Sikar, Jaipur region

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - Ganeshwar, famous for its hoard of copper objects, is in which district? Answer: Sikar.

TRAP

Ganeshwar is in Sikar; Sunari is in Jhunjhunu. Both are Shekhawati, both sit on the Kantli, and both are about metal - but Ganeshwar is copper and Chalcolithic, Sunari is iron and Iron Age. Do not let the shared river fool you.

Kalibangan - the one Harappan site of Rajasthan

Kalibangan in Hanumangarh is the star of this chapter, and it also appears in the Indus Valley chapter of Indian History. It sits on the left bank of the dry Ghaggar. The name means black bangles, from the bangle fragments littering the mound. Do not learn it as a description - learn it as a list of firsts and onlys, because that is exactly how it is asked.

Kalibangan - the firsts and onlys

Ploughed field

world's earliest; pre-Harappan

Double fortification

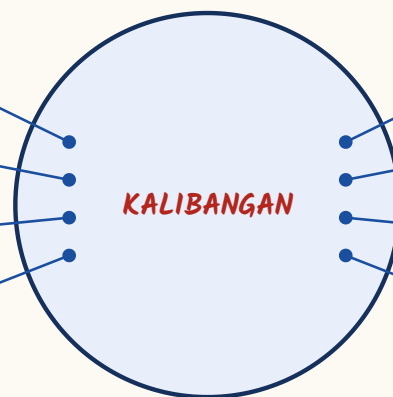
citadel and lower town both

Earthquake

evidence from about 2600 BCE

Bricks

3:2:1 early, 4:2:1 mature



Fire altars

a row of seven on the citadel

No covered drains

unlike Mohenjo-daro

Cylinder seal

woman between two spearmen

Ghaggar, left bank

Hanumangarh district

- World's earliest attested ploughed field - pre-Harappan, with criss-cross furrows.
- A row of seven fire altars on the citadel mound.
- The only Harappan site where both the citadel and the lower town were fortified.
- No elaborate covered drainage system - the opposite of Mohenjo-daro.
- Evidence of an earthquake around 2600 BCE.
- A cylinder seal showing a woman between two spear-bearing men; three types of burial.

Who found what at Kalibangan - the discovery chain

Luigi Pio Tessitori draws attention, 1917-18



A. Ghosh identifies it as Harappan, 1951-52



B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar excavate, 1961-69



Site museum opens, 1983

Kalibangan Period I vs Period II - the brick question

Period I - pre-Harappan	Period II - Mature Harappan
Bricks 30 x 20 x 10 cm	Bricks 30 x 15 x 7.5 cm
Ratio 3 : 2 : 1	Ratio 4 : 2 : 1
The ploughed field belongs to this phase	Fortified citadel and fortified lower town

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the excavation of Kalibangan between 1961 and 1969 was directed by whom? Answer: B.B. Lal, with B.K. Thapar. A. Ghosh only identified the mound, in 1951-52 - that is the distractor.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 as a statement question - both citadel and lower town fortified (true), seven fire altars on the citadel (true), elaborate covered drainage like Mohenjo-daro (false). Answer: statements I and II only.

TRAP

The drainage statement is the standard false option. Kalibangan had no developed covered drainage. And its lower town was fortified - if a statement says unfortified, it is wrong.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - no pre-historic site of Rajasthan is on the UNESCO World Heritage List. The state's inscribed properties are the Hill Forts of Rajasthan (2013), Jantar Mantar Jaipur (2010), the Walled City of Jaipur (2019) and Keoladeo National Park (1985). Kalibangan is a centrally protected ASI site with its own museum since 1983. If an option pairs Kalibangan with UNESCO, it is wrong.

The Iron Age and early historic mounds

Now the metal changes. Iron appears in the north-east and east of the state, along with punch-marked coins and the beginnings of the town. Three names carry this section - Sunari, Rairh and Noh. Learn the third column of the table below; that is the column that gets asked.

Iron Age and early historic sites

Site	District	Setting	Famous for
Sunari	Jhunjhunu	Kantli river	Earliest iron-smelting furnaces reported from Rajasthan
Rairh	Tonk	Dheel river	3,075 punch-marked coins, huge iron slag heaps
Noh	Bharatpur	Eastern plain	Four-fold sequence OCP - BRW - PGW - NBPW; Jakh Baba yaksha
Nagari	Chittorgarh	Ancient Madhyamika	Capital of the Shivi janapada
Rang Mahal	Hanumangarh	Ghaggar	Swedish expedition; Kushana-Gupta material
Bhinmal	Jalore	Western Rajasthan	Roman and Greek wine vessels, Shaka-period material

- Rairh was excavated by K.N. Puri in 1938-39 and is called the Tata Nagar of ancient India for its iron working.
- The colossal yaksha statue worshipped locally as Jakh Baba came from Noh.
- The Ghosundi-Hathibada inscription was found close to Nagari.
- Rang Mahal was dug by a Swedish expedition led by Hanna Rydh, 1952-54 - the only Rajasthan site dug by a foreign woman archaeologist, which is why it gets asked.
- Bhinmal was excavated by R.C. Agrawal, 1953-54.
- Baror (Sri Ganganagar) and Sothi (Bikaner) are Ghaggar-valley pre-Harappan and Harappan sites; A. Ghosh named the Sothi culture after Sothi.
- Jhadol (Udaipur), Pindpadaliya (Chittorgarh), Malah (Bharatpur), Kurada (Nagaur) and Sabaniya of the western desert belt are the smaller proto-historic finds.

Bairath - Ashoka, the Buddha and a circular temple

Bairath, also called Viratnagar, in the Jaipur region, is the odd one out in this chapter. It is not a Chalcolithic village at all - it is a Mauryan and Buddhist centre. Daya Ram Sahni excavated it in 1936-37. It links straight into the Mauryan chapter of Indian History, so learn it once and use it twice.

- Two minor rock edicts of Ashoka have been reported from Bairath.
- The Bhabru edict, also called the Calcutta-Bairat edict, names the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha.
- That edict is no longer at the site - it is preserved in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata.
- Bijak-ki-Pahadi at Bairath has India's oldest free-standing circular Buddhist temple, a chaitya-griha.
- A jar containing punch-marked silver coins and Indo-Greek coins was found here.
- Bhim ji ki Dungri and Ganesh Dungri are the site's other mounds.

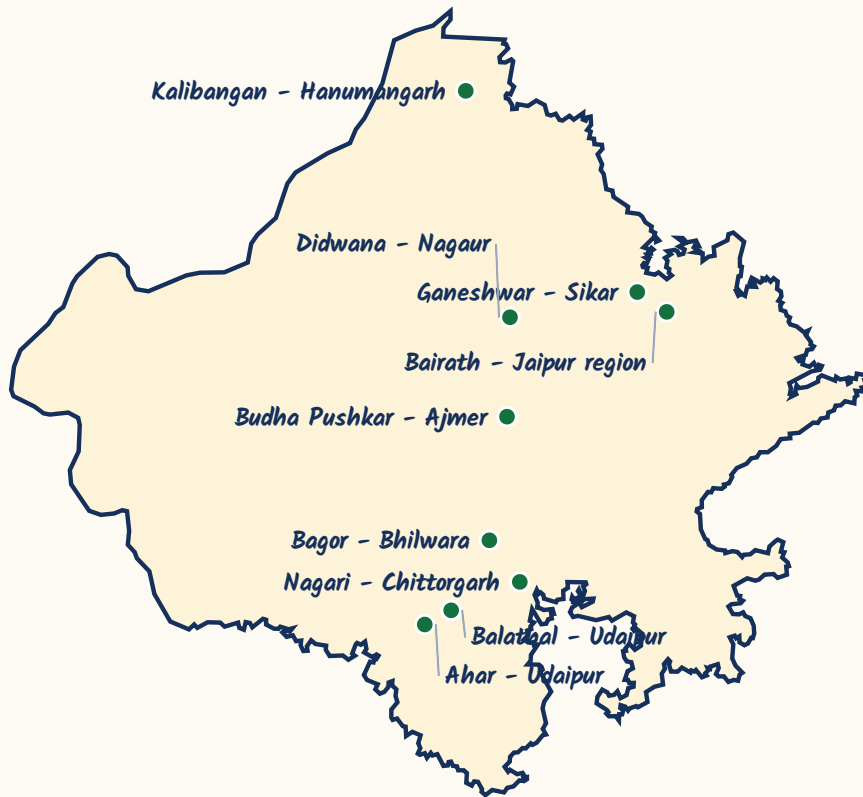
ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - the Bhabru rock edict of Ashoka, which mentions the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha, was found at? Answer: Bairath. Note the follow-up trap - it is now kept in Kolkata.

Two drills you must actually do - pottery and excavators

Everything above collapses into two matching tables. Say these out loud until they are automatic. In a matching question you will not have time to reconstruct them from the story.

Site to district - the whole chapter on one map



Harappan only on the Ghaggar; copper cultures north-east and south

The four diagnostic wares

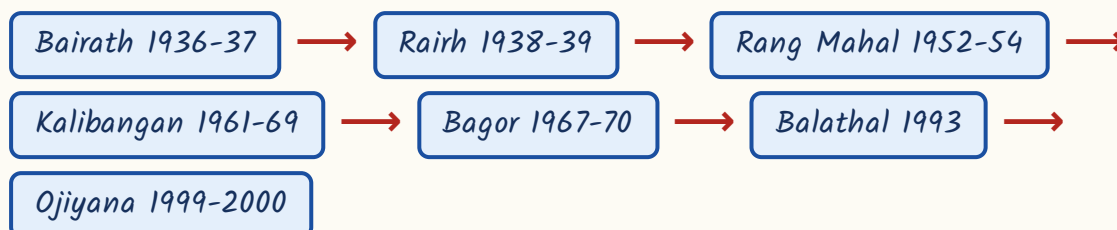
Ware	Full name	Where it is prominent
OCP	Ochre Coloured Pottery	Ganeshwar, Jodhpura, Noh
BRW	Black-and-Red Ware	Ahar, Gilund, Balathal - with white linear designs
PGW	Painted Grey Ware	Noh, Jodhpura
NBPW	Northern Black Polished Ware	Noh, Rairh - the early historic layer

Site to excavator to year - the most-asked table in the chapter

Site	Excavator	Year(s)
Bairath	Daya Ram Sahnii	1936-37
Rairh	K.N. Puri	1938-39
Rang Mahal	Hanna Rydh (Swedish expedition)	1952-54
Bhinmal	R.C. Agrawal	1953-54

Site	Excavator	Year(s)
Ahar	R.C. Agrawal & H.D. Sankalia	1961-62
Kalibangan	B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar	1961-69
Tilwara	V.N. Misra	1967-68
Bagor	V.N. Misra	1967-70
Balathal	V.N. Misra	from 1993
Ojijana	B.R. Meena	1999-2000
Gilund	B.B. Lal; later V.S. Shinde & G.L. Possehl	-
Ganeshwar	R.C. Agrawal & Vijay Kumar	-

Excavation years in order - RPSC has asked this as an ordering question



YAAD RAKHO

Learn the men, not the sites, and half the matching solves itself. V.N. Misra owns three - Bagor, Tilwara, Balathal. R.C. Agrawal owns three - Ahar, Ganeshwar, Bhinmal. B.B. Lal owns two - Kalibangan and the first dig at Gilund.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - every site in this chapter that is centrally protected falls under the Archaeological Survey of India's Jaipur Circle, which is also the circle that dug Ojijana under B.R. Meena in 1999-2000 and which runs the Kalibangan site museum opened in 1983. If a question asks who protects or excavates these mounds, the answer is the ASI, not the state department of archaeology.

REVISION RECAP

1. Ladder order: Didwana - Bagor - Ahar - Kalibangan - Sunari.
2. Ahar = Tambavati = copper; Udaipur; Ayad-Berach; also Aghatpur / Aghatdurg.
3. Ahar culture = Banas culture, c. 2800-1500 BCE, Black-and-Red Ware with white designs, almost no microliths.
4. Balathal - Udaipur, V.N. Misra from 1993, fortified enclosure, oldest leprosy skeleton in India.
5. Ojiyana - Bhilwara, B.R. Meena, 1999-2000, painted bull and cow figurines.
6. Gilund - Rajsamand, on the Banas, first dug by B.B. Lal.
7. Ganeshwar - Sikar (Neem ka Thana), Kantli, 2,000+ copper objects, OCP; supplied copper to the Harappans.
8. Jodhpura sits on the Sabi; Kurada (Nagaur) is a copper-hoard site.
9. Bagor - Bhilwara, Kothari, V.N. Misra 1967-70, largest Mesolithic site of India, domestication c. 5000 BCE.
10. Tilwara - Barmer, on the Luni, Mesolithic, V.N. Misra 1967-68.
11. Kalibangan - Hanumangarh, left bank of Ghaggar, B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar 1961-69, name means black bangles.
12. Kalibangan firsts: earliest ploughed field, seven fire altars, both citadel and lower town fortified, no covered drainage.
13. Kalibangan bricks - Period I 30x20x10 (3:2:1), Period II 30x15x7.5 (4:2:1); earthquake c. 2600 BCE.
14. Bairath - two Ashokan minor rock edicts; Bhabru edict now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata; Daya Ram Sahni 1936-37.
15. Bijak-ki-Pahadi - India's oldest free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya-griha.
16. Rairh - Tonk, Dheel, K.N. Puri 1938-39, 3,075 punch-marked coins, Tata Nagar of ancient India.
17. Sunari - Jhunjhunu, Kantli, earliest iron-smelting furnaces in Rajasthan; Noh - Bharatpur, four wares, Jakh Baba.
18. Nagari - ancient Madhyamika, Shivi janapada capital; Rang Mahal - Hanna Rydh, Swedish, 1952-54.
19. Wares: OCP - Ganeshwar; BRW - Ahar; PGW - Noh; NBPW - Noh and Rairh.